

Professionalism and ethical conduct (behavior)

Lecture three

Lecture objectives

- Identify ethical issues that arise in professional decision making and determine how to address them.
- Analyze global computing issues that influence professional decision making.
- Describe the mechanisms that typically exist for day-to-day ethical decision making.
- Identify progressive stages in an illegal incident.
- Specify the strengths and weaknesses of relevant professional codes as expressions of professionalism and guides to decision making.

Introduction

- A profession (occupation/vocation) is a trade, a business, or an occupation of which one professes (allows/agrees/affirms one's faith in) to have **extensive knowledge** acquired through long years of **experience** and **formal education**, the **autonomy** and **responsibility** to make independent decisions in carrying out the duties of the profession.

Pillars of Professionalism

Professionalism is supported by four pillars:

- ❖ **Commitment**- a willingness to give your time and energy to something that you believe in, or a promise
- ❖ **Integrity**-Integrity means a state of undivided loyalty(fidelity/dependability) to self-belief. It is honesty, and incorruptible.
- ❖ **Responsibility**- deals with roles, tasks, and actions and their resultant consequences. For example, as parents we have an obligation and a duty to bring up our offspring (descendent).
- ❖ **Accountability**- is the obligation to answer for the execution of one's assigned responsibilities.

Requirements of a Professional (expert/specialized)

- There are three basic professional requirements, and over the years as the professions evolved, these three elements have taken different forms. They are:
 - ❖ *A set of highly developed skills and deep knowledge of the domain.*
 - ❖ *Autonomy.*
 - ❖ *Observance (execution) of a code of conduct.*
 - ❖ A **Code of Conduct** is a written collection of the rules, principles, values, and employee expectations, behaviour, and relationships that an organization considers significant and believes are fundamental to their successful operation.

A set of highly developed skills and deep knowledge of the domain.

- Although professional skills are developed through long years of experience, such skills must be backed up by a very well-developed **knowledge base** acquired through long years of **formal schooling**. Acquiring a sophisticated level of knowledge is crucial because skills based on shallow (low) knowledge of the domain could be damaging to the profession in cases involving decisions that require understanding, analysis, and adoption of concepts to suit the environment or the problem.

Autonomy.

- Because professionals provide either products or services, there is always a relationship between the **provider** of the service and **the receiver** of the service or the provider of the product and the receiver of the product.
- In this relationship we are concerned with the power balance. In the case of a professional, the power is in favor of the professional. Take the relationship between a lawyer and a client or a physician and a patient, for example. In either case, there is a power play in favor of the provider of the service.

Observance of a code of conduct.

- A working professional usually observes these **four types** of codes
- (i) **The professional code:** a set of guidelines provided to the professional by the profession spelling out what a professional ought (must) to do and not do. A professional code protects both the **image** of the profession and that of the **individual members**. Thus, it is a requirement for the profession that members adhere (follow) to the code.

Observance of a code of conduct.

- (ii) A personal code: a set of individual moral guidelines on which professionals operate. In many ways these guidelines are acquired by professionals from the **cultural environment** in which they grow up or **live in** and the **religious beliefs** they may practice.
- A personal code supplements the professional code significantly.

Observance of a code of conduct.

- (iii) **The community code:** a community standard code developed over a period of time based on either the **religion or culture** of the **indigenous (homegrown/native) people** in the area.
- It may be imposed by civil (public) law or the culture of the community in which the professional works.

Observance of a code of conduct.

- (iv) **institutional code:** a code imposed by the institution for which the professional is working.
- This code is meant to build and maintain the public's confidence in the institution and its employees.

Ethical codes

- These are rules that govern a particular group of people against which quality is measured.
- Ethical codes will help a particular group of people to compare a behavior whose quality is doubted.
- For instance professions survive through ethical codes; failure to observe ethical codes usually leads to court.

Objectives of the Ethical codes

- ❖ **Ensuring disciplinary-** instilling (teaching/introducing) discipline
- ❖ **Advisory-** source of tips (guidelines) to members and offer advice and guidance.
- ❖ **Educational-** good educational tools for members of the domain.
- ❖ **Inspirational** – should carry subliminal messages to those using them to inspire them to be “good.”
- ❖ **Publicity:-** Create good public relations.

Codes of Ethics and Professional Organizations

- Several professional organizations have established codes of conduct/ethics.
- Codes of ethics can have **positive effect** on an individual's judgment regarding computer use; unfortunately, many employers do not encourage joining of these professional organizations.
- Examples of ethical codes include;

Association of Computing Machinery (ACM)

- The ACM's code of ethics requires members to perform their duties in a manner benefitting an ethical computing professional.
- Code of ethics contains references to **protecting information confidentiality, causing no harm, protecting others' privacy, and respecting others' intellectual property**

International Information Systems Security Certification Consortium, Inc. (ISC)²

- Non-profit organization focusing on development and implementation of information security certifications and credentials
- The Code of ethics was primarily designed for information security professionals who have certification from (ISC)² . It focuses on four mandatory canons.
 - ❖ **Protect society, the commonwealth, and the infrastructure;**
 - ❖ **Act honorably, honestly, justly, responsibly, and legally;**
 - ❖ **Provide diligent and competent service to principals; and**
 - ❖ **Advance and protect the profession.**

Others include

- System Administration, Networking, and Security Institute (SANS)
- Information Systems Audit and Control Association (ISACA)
- Information Systems Security Association (ISSA)
- Internet Society (ISOC)
- Computer Security Division (CSD)

Professionalism and Ethical Responsibilities

- This include whistle-blowing, harassment, and discrimination.

Whistle-Blowing

- The term whistle-blowing gives the impression of an act of seeking public attention.- including a higher authority such as a government.
- It is meant to alert and call the public to be witnesses to illegal acts that may be hazardous to their health and well-being or to waste of public resources.
- Whistle-blowing methods have been used for years, ranging from traditional ones to more modern computer-aided ones.

Professionalism and Ethical Responsibilities

- **Harassment and Discrimination**
- **Harassment** is to verbally or physically create an environment that is hostile, intimidating, offensive, severe, pervasive, or abusive based on a number of parameters including one's race, religion, sex, sexual orientation, national origin, age, disability, political affiliation, marital status, citizenship, or physical appearance.

Professionalism and Ethical Responsibilities

- **Harassment and Discrimination**
- **Discrimination** on the other hand is a process of making decisions that negatively affect an individual, such as denial of a service, based wholly, or partly, upon the real or perceived facts of one's race, religion, sex, sexual orientation, national origin, age, disability, political affiliation, marital status, or physical appearance

Ethical analysis

- Ethical analysis is evaluation of human actions and/ theories basing on certain values. Ethical analysis is achieved through **reasoning** and **logic because of their nature**.
- Ethical issues are not linear hence cannot be followed using a linear model.

Ethical analysis

- In ethical analysis we use ethical decision making is the process that involves evaluation of a number of decisions to reach a consensus.
- The whole process involves;
 - ❖ Recognize the inherent ethical problem
 - ❖ Identify actors involved
 - ❖ Be aware of alternatives
 - ❖ Demonstrating knowledge of ethical practices
 - ❖ Understand how the decision will be implemented and who will be affected
 - ❖ Understand and comprehend the impact of the decision of the parties involved

Revision Exercise

1. Define professionalism and list three elements of professionalism.
2. Why are the following concepts important for professionalism? Justify your answers.
3. Is computer technology negatively or positively affecting harassment and discrimination?
4. Discuss the effects of whistle-blowing on a whistle-blower.